

ARMOURED MIGHT
Russian-made T90 'Bhishma' tanks of the Indian Army at an exercise in Rajasthan



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-LT GEN. ANIL AHUJA (RETD)
Former Deputy Chief of Integrated Defence Staff

And the Russian-made Mi35 attack helicopter fleet is being replaced by a steady trickle of Boeing Apaches.

Experts point out that India has an urgent need for proven systems, rather than continued dependence on an unreliable Russian defence industrial base. Demonstrating commitment to reforming defence procurement processes to enable greater ease of importing western defence technologies—with key offers like the US-made MQ-9B drones on the table—can enable faster induction of these systems. This can also drive indigenous production through negotiating co-production clauses. The emphasis is on acquiring state-of-the-art systems not only for conventional warfare but also to meet India's intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR) and maritime domain awareness requirements. Western countries are deemed better placed in these advanced technology systems.

Amit Cowshish, former financial advisor (acquisition) to the ministry of defence, believes that with declining investment in R&D and disruption in defence production that impacted spare parts delivery and other technical support, the Russian defence industry has lost some of its edge. "Aggressive competition from the US, France, Israel etc. opened up new avenues for India. It also fitted into New Delhi's fierce quest for strategic autonomy," Cowshish says. However, he adds that it's not the end of the road between India and its trusted ally Russia, especially when considering the latter's significance vis-a-vis India-China relations.

Liberal Technology Transfers

Experts further point out that compared with western nations, Russia has been more liberal in transferring technology to India and more willing to cooperate in co-development and co-production ventures. India stands to gain as much as Russia from this, even if they are forced to lie low for some time because of the Ukraine conflict and international sanctions.

Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), former Deputy Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (policy planning and force development), who was also the founding co-chair of the India-US Defence Technology and Trade Initiative (DTTI), points out that India's legacy relationship with the Soviet Union/ Russia started when the US was not willing to sell us defence hardware. Naturally, this pushed us into a near "sole dependency" on Russia, which was not a desirable position, he adds. "Although defence imports from Russia have reduced in monetary value, it still ranks higher than any other partner in the depth of technology shared (or sold). BrahMos missiles, the proposed lease of a nuclear submarine, the sale of S-400s and cooperation in other strategic programmes all suggest the existence of a much higher level of mutual trust," says Lt Gen. Ahuja. He adds that along with co-development programmes with government agencies, Russia will now have to learn to work with the Indian private sector to help create an ecosystem to support indigenisation.

India aims to achieve strategic autonomy by not being overly reliant on any one country for its defence requirements. This involves building partnerships with western countries and enhancing domestic capabilities at the same time. But it has to do this while keeping its strategic balance with Russia intact, for despite the recent downturn in military trade, Moscow remains a significant defence partner. However, with diversification of defence procurement and self-reliance expected to continue, Russia's share in India's defence imports over time can fall further with the replacement of older platforms. ■